CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

WEDDING PHOTOGRAPHER IN THE AI ERA

One unrepeatable day, two hundred guests, zero second takes — couples pay for the person who has proven they will not miss it.

★ **TL;DR — Around $75K median for specialists who can build skill and a portfolio in 1–6 months and then season it. The catch: your weekends are gone and the pressure per frame is unmatched.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

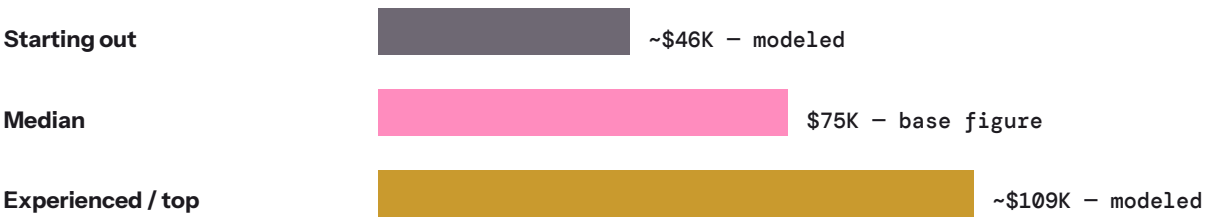
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Why it works: weddings are one of the few events people still budget seriously for, and photos outlast everything else bought that day.
- Where it bites: a wedding day is a marathon with no reschedule button.
- The AI angle: AI edits and culls beautifully — it cannot be in the room, read the family politics and catch the tear at the vows.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Wedding Photographer is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A WEDDING PHOTOGRAPHER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Shoot 8–12 hour wedding days: prep, ceremony, portraits, party
- ✓ Direct family group photos fast, kindly and without chaos
- ✓ Run a backup-everything system: cards, bodies, drives, cloud
- ✓ Edit and deliver galleries, albums and sneak peeks on deadline

Think: a documentary filmmaker and an air-traffic controller sharing one body for twelve hours.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI culling and editing have collapsed post-production time. Album design, gallery hosting and client emails run largely on software now.	The day itself is pure human work: anticipation, positioning, calm under family pressure, and being liked enough that people relax. Couples buy the person as much as the pictures.

⚠ **One corrupted card can end the business before it starts. Redundant gear and backups are not paranoia — they are the product.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Happy rooms, dressed-up people, real emotion ✓ Premium day rates for proven shooters ✓ Weekdays free in trade for weekends	✗ Every Saturday, spoken for, a year ahead ✗ 12-hour days on your feet, in the heat ✗ Emotional stakes: you cannot reshoot a first kiss

Good fit? You are unflappable, fast, warm with strangers, and a little obsessive about backups.
Bad fit? You crumble under time pressure, hate crowds, or want your weekends sacred.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — SECOND SHOOTER	DOOR B — SMALL WEDDINGS FIRST
The industry's real apprenticeship: shoot under lead photographers for a season. You learn timelines, lighting in bad churches and worse ballrooms, and build a portfolio from real weddings with permission.	Elopements, courthouse weddings and micro-weddings are shorter, cheaper and lower-stakes. Book them deliberately as paid training while you build reviews toward full days.

Smart move: Befriend planners and venues, not just couples. One planner who trusts you is a season of weddings; one couple is a day.
Where you land after: A signature wedding brand with associate shooters, destination work, or a hybrid photo-video team.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MASTER YOUR	SECOND-SHOO A	BUILD REDUNDANCY	PORTFOLIO FROM	BOOK YOUR	RAISE INTO

STEP 1 — Master your camera in bad light

FREE · WEEKS 1-3

- Dark halls, mixed light, fast movement — wedding conditions
- Flash basics: bounce, off-camera, no deer-in-headlights

STEP 2 — Second-shoot a season

PAID · MONTHS 1-4

- Work under two or three different lead photographers
- Study timelines and family-photo systems up close

STEP 3 — Build redundancy

$500+ · MONTH 2

- Two bodies, dual-card recording, on-the-day backups
- Insurance — one accident should not end you

STEP 4 — Portfolio from real weddings

MONTHS 2-4

- Full galleries, not just hero shots — couples check consistency
- Styled shoots fill gaps your second-shooting has not covered

STEP 5 — Book your own small weddings

MONTHS 3-6

- Micro-weddings and off-season dates at honest starter prices
- Deliver fast sneak peeks — that speed is marketing

STEP 6 — Raise into full days

MONTH 6+

- Price full days once reviews and galleries prove you
- Vendor relationships become your booking engine

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: practice shooting in the worst light you can find at home.

□ Days 1–30: line up second-shooter dates; build your backup system.

□ Days 31–60: shoot real weddings under leads; start your portfolio site.

□ Days 61–90: book your first small wedding of your own.

□ Day 90: a working second shooter with first solo bookings — full seasons are built one wedding at a time.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ NO SECOND TAKES. EVER. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.